

On the Evolution of Qualitative Methods in Organizational Research

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Keywords

qualitative methods, grounded theory, case studies, ethnography, artificial
intelligence in qualitative research, language challenges in qualitative
research

Abstract

I explore how qualitative research has evolved in organizational research by
examining developments in two major areas: how we do qualitative research
and how we evaluate it. In particular, I track broad changes in case study,
grounded theory, and ethnographic methods, as well as changes in various
analytic practices or “moves” common across each as they relate to study de-
sign and data collection, coding and analysis, and writing and publishing. In
reviewing where the field has been, I discuss areas where qualitative methods
have been particularly strong and where there are opportunities for growth.
I conclude by discussing the future of qualitative methods as they pertain
to the global proliferation of qualitative research, the ongoing challenges to
positivist science, and the emergence of artificial intelligence.

INTRODUCTION

One illustrative way to capture how qualitative research has evolved in our field is to note that it both “counts less and counts more.” It counts less by diverging from positivist criteria that equated theme counting as an indicator of research quality (Pratt 2008). It counts more as interest in qualitative methods has burgeoned in recent years.¹ To illustrate, there are several journals listed in the Financial Times (FT) Top 50, including the *Academy of Management Journal* (AMJ), *Administrative Science Quarterly* (ASQ), *Human Relations*, and *Organization Science*, that have multiple editors whose primary area of methodological expertise is qualitative.² Additionally, top journals in organizational psychology such as the *Journal of Applied Psychology* and *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes* now seek out and accept qualitative manuscripts. This is quite a change from when I was the lone associate editor for qualitative manuscripts at the AMJ in 2007! Moreover, qualitative research has an outsized influence in terms of awards (Bartunek et al. 2006, Rynes & Bartunek 2015). Pursuant to both points, the two top management papers named as the most interesting in the past 100 years by AMJ board members contained both qualitative data and counting (Bartunek et al. 2006). Yet, when looking at the best papers in ASQ and AMJ from 2003 to 2012, we see most are qualitative, and counting (themes) all but disappears. The purpose of this review is to make sense of these and other changes by tracing the evolution of qualitative research in the organizational literature and suggesting areas where it might still go.

The challenges of tracing the evolution of qualitative research in organizational studies are numerous. Qualitative research comprises many methodologies, each with an extensive history. Moreover, these different methodologies have largely developed in disciplines outside of organizational psychology/organizational behavior, such as anthropology, sociology, and education. Within and between these disciplines there are different approaches, even within the same methodology (e.g., grounded theory), which follow from different ontological and epistemological assumptions. Moreover, to understand evolution, one needs to know what qualitative methods have evolved from and when it started in organizational research. In short, any effort to chronicle the evolution of these methods will be incomplete and provisional and needs to be approached with ample humility.

In the interest of transparency, I made a few decisions in conducting this review. To begin, I largely focus on developments in qualitative research made by scholars in organizational departments and/or scholars publishing in organizational outlets [e.g., *Organizational Research Methods* (ORM)]. In addition, I use the 1979 special issue on qualitative research in ASQ, which was a powerful signal of legitimacy to organizational audiences, as the starting point for my inquiry in the organizational field and trace advancements in the 45 years since that publication (Van Maanen 1979).

Another major decision was deciding what methodologies in qualitative research to focus upon when tracing their evolution over time. Broadly, I focus on those qualitative methods that have received a lion's share of attention in organizational outlets: case studies, grounded theory, and ethnography. These methodologies were also chosen as they have complementary strengths that can guide a researcher through the entire research process. For example, case studies excel at

¹ See Pratt & Bonaccio (2016) for statistics on the prevalence of qualitative research in various management and psychology outlets. More recently, in a personal communication with Christine Beckman, editor of ASQ (8/21/2024), she noted that half of the last 100 papers published in ASQ have utilized historical or other qualitative data.

² Other organizational journals in the FT Top 50 such as *Human Resource Management*, *Journal of Business Ethics*, *Journal of Management*, *Journal of Management Studies*, *Organizational Studies*, and *Strategic Management Journal* have either qualitative editors and/or qualitative researchers on their advisory boards.

study design, grounded theory excels at analysis, and ethnography is particularly strong on data collection (although it also speaks to data analysis). Within these three methodologies, I chose a small group of books (listed later) that have been foundational to research in organizational studies. To these, I also added Lincoln & Guba's (1985) *Naturalistic Inquiry*, an often-cited source when discussing trustworthiness in qualitative research. Taken together, these comprise the sources from which the developments in our field have evolved.

Within these methodologies, I chose two main categories that encompassed main foci for research: how to do qualitative research and how to assess it. From here, I asked three research assistants to pull every article on qualitative methods from *ORM* from its founding in 1998 through early 2024. From these and other articles, I induced several subcategories. Given the scope of the review, my focus trades depth for breadth, and I provide tables and citations if readers desire a deeper dive into the issues I raise, many of which could fill an entire article. Throughout, I reflect on the areas where we have made progress and where we have perhaps fallen short (or, to put it more optimistically, areas with high growth potential).

Finally, one common practice in qualitative research is to reflect on how one's own identity may influence how one sees the world. In honor of this practice, I acknowledge that the areas I chose to highlight, the problems I see, and the recommendations I offer are deeply shaped by my experiences and who I am. I have been involved in journal editing for nearly 20 years and have made decisions on over 700, mostly qualitative, manuscripts (including revisions). Much of what I write about I have seen firsthand. However, all the journals I have worked with are housed in the same geographical area where I have trained and worked my entire life: North America. These experiences made me more confident to speak about some methods, such as ethnography, than other methods, such as narrative and discourse analyses, which are more common in Europe. Each of the journals I have worked with publishes in English. Together, these experiences allow certain insights but blind me to others. To rectify at least some of these blind spots, I have consulted with, cite, and include insights from authors who are not native English speakers and who work outside of North America and this set of journals. However, I would be delighted if this piece sparks imaginations and conversations about the areas I missed.

QUALITATIVE METHODS IN ORGANIZATIONAL CONTEXTS

Qualitative methods are at the heart of qualitative research. A colleague and I have described the latter in the following way (Pratt & Bonaccio 2016, p. 694):

Qualitative research, broadly defined, refers to “any type of research that produces findings not arrived at by statistical procedures or other means of quantification” (Strauss & Corbin 1998, pp. 10–11). In the *Handbook of Research Methods in Industrial and Organizational Psychology*, Locke and Golden-Biddle (2002) further suggest that qualitative research often is conducted in the field, where the subjects of one's studies are working. It also often refers to methods that involve qualitative data (e.g., text) as well as results that are communicated in a nonquantitative fashion.

Although the specific steps involved in conducting qualitative research are tailored to fit one's research question (Pratt et al. 2022), the general process involves moving from designing the research project, collecting data, analyzing (including but not limited to coding) those data, and theorizing from them to eventually writing up and ideally publishing one's work. A simplified and highly stylized version of the qualitative research process can be found in **Figure 1**. This figure depicts how the various parts of the research process relate to each other, often in an iterative fashion, and a sample of questions one needs to address within each phase.

The past 45 years have seen organizational researchers first translating and then moving beyond classic texts/sources from other disciplines regarding how to conduct qualitative research.



Figure 1

A stylized overview of the qualitative research process: iterative phases and questions to address within each.

Some of these insights flesh out existing methodologies, such as sampling issues in case studies. Others explore practices that are inherent in most qualitative research processes, such as gaining access. Common among these efforts are surfacing and elaborating upon parts of the research process that are either implicit or overlooked in most methodological writing.

One impetus for these efforts may be the increasing popularity of qualitative research that has caused movement away from early, often implicit craft knowledge.³ After first attempting to learn from classic texts from other disciplines, organizational researchers found that these sources offered maps of how to do qualitative research. But the maps were not the territory: They often left out critical parts of the research process, such as the various practices underlying coding or how to move from one's data to theory. As a point of reference, as qualitative research emerged in our field, most scholars were either self-taught and/or apprenticed with more experienced researchers. During this time, moving from methodological maps to the territory involved building implicit

³Qualitative research may be on the ascent because it takes best advantage of why we are organizational scholars rather than simply social psychologists or sociologists. To begin, it takes seriously the notion that organizations matter. Qualitative research is uniquely poised to consider context or situations as it takes place in, and involves interacting with members within, the field (Pratt & Bonacio 2016). In addition, it tends to look at problems in the world to generate theory. This problem focus has the potential to produce knowledge that integrates insights at and between different levels of analysis. Such knowledge has the potential to impact those outside of academia while also building new theory. As such, it addresses the theory-practice tension inherent in studying organizations, especially in business schools.

knowledge gained by doing and supplemented by reading. And when there were relatively few scholars engaged in qualitative research, this appeared to have sufficed, though some might argue that these early idiosyncratic approaches may have created threats to the methods' legitimacy—a topic I approach later in this review.

As qualitative research became more mainstream, pressure arose to make implicit craft knowledge about qualitative methods more explicit, especially for those who did not have access to mentors. Organizational researchers have responded to this need by revisiting every aspect of the research process depicted in **Figure 1**, including study design, data collection, data analysis, and write up. A sample of these examinations can be found in **Table 1**.

I discuss two areas where advancements have been made: (a) translating and extending case study, grounded theory, and ethnographic methods from other disciplines and (b) focusing on practices that transcend specific methodologies (e.g., gaining access). Throughout, I focus on analytical moves, which are defined as “specific methodological choices made by the author” (Pratt et al. 2022, p. 215). For example, within analysis, an analytical move might be generating an in vivo code using informants' own language versus creating an abstracted code. I pay special attention to coding and analysis and also writing, as these areas have received considerable attention.

Translating and Extending Case Study, Grounded Theory, and Ethnographic Methods from Other Disciplines

As noted, qualitative research flourished in other disciplines well before it did in organizational scholarship. As such, qualitative researchers have drawn and continue to draw upon source material in those disciplines when conducting qualitative research. Some of these foundational texts include Yin's (1984) *Case Study Research: Design and Methods*, Spradley's (1979) *The Ethnographic Interview*, and Glaser & Strauss's (1967) *Discovery of Grounded Theory: Strategies for Qualitative Research*—and later iterations of grounded theory (Charmaz 2014, Glaser 1992, Strauss & Corbin 1998). These are not, of course, the only major sources in these disciplines. In the area of case studies, for example, Stake's (1995) *The Art of Case Study Research* is a wonderful book for interpretivist scholars. However, it has not gained the purchase in our field that Yin's work has.

Beyond simply drawing on these source materials, organizational scholars have attempted to translate them for organizational audiences. In grounded theory, for example, Locke's (2001) *Grounded Theory in Management Research* not only provides a comprehensive view of the method and its variations but also discusses its unique applications in organizational research (see also Martin & Turner 1986, Suddaby 2006, Turner 1983). More recently, Gioia and colleagues (2013) have provided a systematic take on grounded theory known as the Gioia Method. One of the key features it adds to grounded theorizing is the inclusion of a data table/figure that assists researchers' articulation of their chain of evidence: how they went from data to theorizing.

In case study research, Eisenhardt has been especially central in adapting and extending Yin's (1984) approach to case studies, although her approach is better described as a combination of Yin's approach and Glaser & Strauss' (1967) grounded theory. The inclusion of grounded theory was important as there was little in Yin's early work regarding how to analyze qualitative case studies. Indeed, as noted by Piekkari & Welch (2018), Yin's main focus was on theory-testing cases, not inductive ones. Eisenhardt's (1989) “Building theories from case study research” provides an early articulation of her approach. More recently, she published a refined version of the Eisenhardt Method that not only captures different means of designing case studies (e.g., racing) but also attempts to loosen the ontological and epistemological assumptions of the method, which historically has its roots in positivism (Eisenhardt 2021).

Table 1 Evolution in how we do research

Area of contribution	Description	Illustrative example(s)
Designing research and collecting data	Research questions	Alvesson & Sandberg 2011, 2013; Pratt 2015
	Comparative research design	Bechky & O'Mahoney 2015
	Case replication logic	Eisenhardt 1989, 2021
	Qualitative restudies/reexaminations	Köhler et al. 2023, Pratt et al. 2024
	Managing difficult informant dynamics (e.g., withdrawal, resistance)	Dundon & Ryan 2010, Thorpe 2014
	Gaining access	Feldman et al. 2004, Peticca-Harris et al. 2016
	Global and team-based multisite ethnography	Jarzabkowski et al. 2015, Smets et al. 2014
	Collecting observational data	Pratt & Sala 2021
	Data collection via video	Gylfe et al. 2016, LeBaron et al. 2018
	Immersion in the field	Dumont 2023
	Role identity/researcher stance	Bolade-Ogunfodun et al. 2023, Cunliffe & Karunanayake 2013
	Video and digital ethnography	Akemu & Abdelnour 2020, Hassard et al. 2018, Jarrett & Liu 2018, Smets et al. 2014, Whiting et al. 2018
Analyzing (including coding) and theorizing	Abduction	Bamberger 2018, Behfar & Okhuysen 2018, Locke et al. 2008
	Coding and analysis practices	Grodal et al. 2021; Locke et al. 2015, 2022; Pratt 2023
	Analyzing process data	Langley 1999, Langley & Ravasi 2019
	Member checks	Locke & Velamuri 2009
	Translating and extending grounded theory for organizational studies	Gioia et al. 2013; Locke 1996, 2001; Martin & Turner 1986; O'Reilly et al. 2012; Suddaby 2006; Turner 1983
	Translating and extending case studies for organizational studies	Eisenhardt 1989, 2021; Hoon 2013
	Translating and extending ethnography for organizational studies	Pratt 2023
Writing and publishing	Pushing back against overly narrow views of cases, grounded theory, and methodological templates	Locke et al. 2022, Mees-Buss et al. 2022, Piekari & Welch 2018, Pratt et al. 2022, Welch et al. 2011
	Ethnographies	Van Maanen 1988, Zilber & Zanoni 2022
	Case studies	Gibbert & Ruigrok 2010
	General	Bansal & Corley 2012; Golden-Biddle & Locke 1997; Jonsen et al. 2018; Köhler 2016; Langley & Klag 2019; Pratt 2008, 2009; Rockmann & Vough 2023

Green = focused primarily on case studies; yellow = focused primarily on ethnography; blue = focused primarily on grounded theory.

Unlike grounded theory and case study researchers, organizational ethnographers have fewer canonical texts. I list Spradley's (1979) *The Ethnographic Interview* as foundational, as researchers have adopted some of his interviewing practices, such as utilizing grand tour questions that ask informants to walk a researcher through parts of their work lives. Other parts of his methodology have had less impact. Indeed, my recent attempt to explain his coding and analysis to organizational audiences was largely motivated by my inability to find it done elsewhere (Pratt 2023). I concur

with Van Maanen (2010, p. 251) who notes that “there is still not much of a technique attached to ethnography despite the last twenty years of trying to develop a standard methodology.”

Perhaps due to these different starting points—reliance on a relatively bounded set of disciplinary texts versus not—development across the methodologies has been quite different. To illustrate, the more standardized approaches to grounded theory and case studies, namely the Gioia and Eisenhardt Methods, have been immensely influential in our field. However, despite warnings from their originators to not use either in an inflexible, “cookbook” fashion, the two approaches have been criticized as being templates (Langley & Abdallah 2011). In fact, *ORM* published a special issue in 2022 that focused on the dangers of methodological templates and on alternatives regarding their use (Köhler & Lambert 2022). I review some of the specific suggestions raised later in this article. However, at a field level, there has been movement to break away from templates and embrace (a) a richer palette of qualitative methods beyond grounded theory and case studies and (b) more leeway in how one does research even within a specific methodology (Piekkari & Welch 2018, Welch et al. 2011).

Whereas the trajectory in grounded theory and case studies has moved toward increasing standardization and then away from it, ethnography, if anything, has become broader (and perhaps more fragmented) in its approach. Organizational ethnographers have continued to push methodological boundaries, either by focusing on particular dilemmas or challenges in using the method or by drawing upon new technologies that allow ethnographers to gather data in new ways. Regarding the former, organizational ethnographers have revisited core practices, such as how to attain immersion within field sites (Dumont 2023). They have also explored more deeply the role of the researcher in the research process, such as their identities and research stances (Bolade-Ogunfodun et al. 2023, Cunliffe & Karunanayake 2013). Perhaps most fundamentally, organizational ethnographers have moved beyond the classic ethnographic model of a single researcher at a single site (Marcus 1995). Jarzabkowski and colleagues (2015), for example, embody this shift by delineating a process for doing team-based and global ethnographies (Jarzabkowski et al. 2015; see also Smets et al. 2014). This shift has been facilitated by the use of technology.

Perhaps more than those utilizing other qualitative approaches, ethnographers have embraced how technology can provide new ways to enact their craft. To illustrate, they have explored the analysis of photographs and other visual data (Shortt & Warren 2019) and have incorporated digital technologies (e.g., Akemu & Abdelnour 2020, Jarrett & Liu 2018, Whiting et al. 2018) as sources of data and data collection. Such approaches allow for greater appreciation of the role of materiality and the body in ethnographic research (Hassard et al. 2018, LeBaron et al. 2018).

Focusing on Practices That Transcend Specific Methodologies

Other advancements have been made by offering insights into core practices inherent in qualitative research more broadly—that is, practices that could be used in ethnographies, case, grounded theory studies, etc.

Design and data collection. As noted in **Table 1**, one area of progress in qualitative methods involves elaborating on analytical moves within the underexplored front-end of the research process. Alvesson & Sandberg (2011, 2013), for example, have developed ways to craft research questions through problematization rather than filling in gaps in the literature (see also Pratt 2015). Within research design, Bechky & O'Mahoney (2015) tackle comparative field research design; Köhler and colleagues (2023, p. 3) examine a process analogous to “replication” by exploring different ways to engage in qualitative “restudies”: an “original empirical study that follows up an earlier piece of research with the purpose of extending existing theory or building new theory,

thus developing the stream of research further.” Moving from design to data collection, Feldman et al.’s (2004) book tackles gaining access (see also Peticca-Harris et al. 2016). Interacting with field sites is not limited to access and initial data collection, however, and Locke & Velamuri (2009) explore different options regarding sharing one’s findings with informants.

Coding and analysis. Coding and analysis have received considerable attention among qualitative researchers. Coding involves “a word or short phrase that symbolically assigns a summative, salient, essence-capturing, and/or evocative attribute for a portion of language-based or visual data” (Saldaña 2021, p. 5). Coding is a part of analysis, with the latter referring to “a systematic way of approaching data for the purpose of better understanding it” (Pratt 2023, p. 2). There have been at least three advancements in this area.

As I have written elsewhere, organizational scholars been particularly good at being reflexive about not only how we code but also the logic behind it (Pratt 2023). Such methodological reflexivity has been critical for pointing out gaps in our knowledge. One critical gap involves moving from coding and analysis to building theory (i.e., theorizing). Classic texts in grounded theory, ethnography, and case studies often overlook or underexplain this critical step. One response to this methodological “black box” is increasing interest in abduction as a means to describe how to theorize (see Sætre & Van de Ven 2021). Often traced to the work of the pragmatist Charles Pierce, abduction is viewed as different from both deduction and induction (for a concise review, see Bamberger 2018) in that it is driven by “an empirical anomaly” and uses observations to create a “plausible knowledge claim” (Behfar & Okhuysen 2018, p. 326). Locke and colleagues (2008), for example, discuss the role of doubt inherent in abduction and its role in theorizing from data.

Beyond abduction, other scholars have explored the logic and practices behind moving from data to theorizing. Grodal and colleagues (2021), for example, view coding as a categorical process (logic) and use theory from categorization to identify specific analytical moves, such as dropping categories, that researchers can use during data analysis (practices). Similarly, Locke and colleagues (2022) identify the movement from concrete to abstract and back again during the analytic process (logic) and identify various coding actions such as engaging with the data (practice).

Finally, one of the most exciting developments in qualitative research with regard to analysis has been Langley’s work on how to move from process data to process theorizing. She refers to her work not as a specific methodology, but rather as an approach or “position” that considers time, change, and dynamism in the world (Gehman et al. 2018, p. 289). Her foundational work, “Strategies for theorizing from process data,” approaches data analysis of events as a bricoleur (Langley 1999). She offers various strategies, not all strictly qualitative, for theorizing from process data including using narratives, cases, and grounded theory. However, she also introduces to organizational audiences new analytical moves such as concept mapping and temporal bracketing. Langley & Ravasi (2019) elaborate concept mapping by exploring different uses of visual artifacts in diagramming and analyzing data, as well as moving from data to theory. Temporal bracketing similarly involves visual artifacts, such as creating timelines of events that delineate specific periods within one’s data. Langley’s process approach has been widely adopted by individuals studying temporality in organizations, often with longitudinal, qualitative data.

Writing and publishing. A final area where organizational methodologists have spent considerable effort is on the writing and publishing of qualitative texts. Two foundational books appeared in the late 1980s and 1990s that continue to have a great impact on current scholarship. The first is Van Maanen’s (1988) *Tales of the Field*. The second book is Golden-Biddle & Locke’s (1997) *Composing Qualitative Research*. Both are in their second editions. For these scholars, writing is viewed as central to the methodological process and thus worthy of our attention. Golden-Biddle & Locke (1997, p. 1) begin their book by noting “we are at the core a profession of text writers”

and emphasize the importance of rhetoric. Van Maanen (2010, p. 240) opens his “A song for my supper: More tales from the field” by noting, “To get quickly to the heart of the matter, the shameful truth of any research trade is that we traffic in communications and communications implies that we intend to alter the views of our readers.”

Building on these foundations, there have been several papers and editorials (e.g., Bansal & Corley 2012, Köhler 2016, Pratt 2009) in organizational journals about how to write and publish studies that utilize qualitative methods. In “Fitting oval pegs into round holes: tensions in evaluating and publishing qualitative research in top-tier North American journals,” I tackled three primary tensions qualitative researchers face when attempting to publish in top-tier North American journals: facing higher standards for publishing, evaluators’ use of inappropriate quantitative criteria, and the lack of a boilerplate for writing up qualitative findings; I also offered publication advice (Pratt 2008). Drawing inspiration from Golden-Biddle & Locke (1993), Jonsen et al. (2018) induce how authors persuade their readers, focusing on how rhetorical and other practices communicate relevance, accountability, and rigor. And Langley & Klag (2019) offer a compelling analysis regarding how to represent one’s involvement in the field in one’s writing. Noting the competing demands for depicting one’s closeness to one’s informants while also maintaining professional distance, they discuss different ways of managing this paradox through one’s visibility, voice, stance, and reflexivity. Most recently, Rockmann & Vough (2023) offer new practices to structure both prewriting and writing phases of one’s qualitative research. Although these efforts looked at qualitative research writing in general, others are more methods focused. Gibbert & Ruigrok (2010) and Zilber & Zanoni (2022), for example, explored writing in case studies and ethnography, respectively. Both offer writing insights for authors.

Taking Stock: “Doing” Qualitative Research

Looking across the various contributions, we find two interrelated movements. First, a movement from map to territory involved organizational researchers first translating and then moving beyond classic texts in other disciplines about how to conduct qualitative research. Some of these insights fleshed out specific methodologies such as case studies, while others looked at practices that are inherent in most qualitative research processes, such as how to gain access. Common among these efforts is surfacing and elaborating on parts of the research process that are implicit and/or are often not part of more classic written texts.

A second, related, movement is evidenced by the ongoing tension between standardization and creativity. As methodical approaches and their analytical moves become more codified, they become more standardized. In response to methodological standardization, there has been push-back from qualitative methodologists to be more creative. Qualitative researchers have offered different approaches for managing this tension, such as practicing methodological bricolage: taking, applying, and innovating analytical moves from different methodologies within a given study (Pratt et al. 2022). In methodological bricolage, one can apply preexisting analytical moves within a study but not apply them formulaically: Specific moves must be arranged in service of one’s research question. In the process, new analytical moves may be created. Effective methodological bricolage involves creativity and expertise, requiring knowledge of both how and why to use a particular analytical move.

To make creative solutions such as methodological bricolage work effectively, a researcher needs to draw upon a wide variety of analytical moves. One approach to increasing the stock of analytical moves involves understanding multiple qualitative methodologies. For decades, there have been calls to more fully embrace the plurality of methods within qualitative research (Prasad 2005). Unfortunately, progress has been slow, especially in North America. Another way

to increase the number of analytical moves is via technology. Movement toward embracing the role of technology in qualitative methods has been uneven. As noted, ethnographic researchers have used technology largely to innovate data collection (e.g., through videos) or as a new source of data (e.g., electronic archival data). There have also been discussions of the role of technology, such as computer-aided qualitative data analysis software (CAQDAS), in assisting qualitative data analysis more broadly (e.g., O’Kane et al. 2021). By “assist,” I mean that major choices about how data are coded, why data are coded the way they are, and how codes are combined and incorporated into the larger analytical process currently remain largely with the researcher. However, methodologists are currently debating the role of technology, especially artificial intelligence (AI), in making these methodological decisions.

ADVANCEMENTS IN ASSESSING QUALITY

Closely bound up in discussions about how to do qualitative research are conversations about assessing its quality. As Seale (1999, p. 465) suggests:

A lot of effort has been expended by methodologists over the years, trying to give some guidance to qualitative researchers in improving or judging the quality of qualitative research. You could say that all methodological writing is ultimately directed at such a goal, because the idea of writing about how one can do research is presumably aimed at giving other people some good ideas on how they might proceed with their own studies.

Assessing quality—which researchers have described in terms of rigor, trustworthiness, truth, validity (and reliability), validation, convincingness, and more—is probably the most contested issue in qualitative research at present. As with “doing” qualitative research, organizational scholars began by closely hewing to criteria developed in other disciplines, but unlike “doing,” where advancements have been primarily on enriching and extending, here qualitative researchers are engaged in more wholesale rethinking of what makes for good qualitative research.

Different means of assessing the “goodness” of methods come from different disciplines with different ontological and epistemological groundings. Two approaches for assessing quality have been particularly influential in management research, and perhaps not surprisingly, both are represented in predominant qualitative templates noted earlier. The first comes from Yin (2003) in his discussion of assessing the quality of case studies. He creates analogs for positivist notions of construct validity, internal validity, external validity, and reliability as indicators of trustworthiness. Eisenhardt and colleagues (Eisenhardt 1989, 2021; Eisenhardt & Graebner 2007) have been prominent adopters of these criteria. The second source is Lincoln & Guba’s (1985) *Naturalistic Inquiry*. These researchers take a more interpretivist stance but also create criteria that are analogous to the various types of validity and reliability central to positivist research. They differ from positivism in their assumption that there are multiple social truths in any research context, and that a researcher’s job is to uncover and give voice to them. The criteria of credibility, transferability, dependability, and conformability have been especially adopted by interpretivist grounded theorists, such as Gioia and colleagues (2012). These criteria, the questions they evoke, and how they are performed via illustrative practices are summarized in **Table 2**.

Quality assessments vary by ontological and epistemological traditions.⁴ What is considered good or truthful depends on how you view the nature of social reality, and by consequence, how you access that reality. New developments in assessing the quality of qualitative research have

⁴Quality assessments are also related to culture and context. Halme and colleagues (2024), for example, show how gold standard practices, such as coding transcribed interviews—a practice central to positivist criteria for good research—may be difficult when studying people with low income in emerging markets.

Table 2 Traditional means of establishing trustworthy qualitative research

<i>Method/approach</i>	<i>Assessment</i>	<i>Defining question</i>	<i>Illustrative practice</i>
Case studies/positivism (Yin 1984)	Construct validity	Can the data be verified? This is a quality of the data, not the investigator.	“Use multiple sources of evidence; establish a chain of evidence; have key informants review draft” (p. 34)
	Internal validity	Is there a causal relationship between variables or constructs?	“Do pattern-matching; do explanation-building; address rival explanations; use logic models” (p. 34)
	External validity	Can findings be generalized and to what domain?	“Use theory in single-case studies; use replication logic in multiple case studies” (p. 34)
	Reliability	Can it be replicated across cases in the study?	“Use case study protocol; develop case study database” (p. 34)
Naturalistic inquiry (Lincoln & Guba 1985)	Credibility	To what degree has the investigator given voice to the different constructions of reality found in one’s data? Credibility is assessed by those one has studied.	“Prolonged engagement” (p. 301); “persistent observation” (p. 304); triangulation (e.g., different data sources, methods, investigators, etc.); “peer debriefing” (p. 308); “negative case analysis” (p. 309); “referential adequacy” (p. 313); “member checks” (p. 314)
	Transferability	Is there contextual similarity between the context one is studying and other contexts? The burden of proof for such a comparison lies with those who want to compare findings to other contexts more than with the original investigator.	Providing a lot of details (e.g., thick description) to “show” not “tell” the reader the findings
	Dependability	Has the investigator taken into account “both factors of instability and factors of phenomenal or design induced change”? (p. 299)	All the practices of credibility plus “stepwise replication” within the dataset (p. 317) and “inquiry audit” (p. 317)
	Confirmability	Was there a process for verifying the data? Confirmability is a characteristic of the data, not the investigator.	Inquiry audit; triangulation; “reflexive journal” (p. 319); “audit trail” (p. 319); “audit process” (p. 320)

Adapted from Pratt et al. (2020, pp. 10–11).

come mostly from interpretivist qualitative researchers who are increasingly uncomfortable with the uninformed or mindless application of positivist criteria in assessing qualitative research. As Sandberg (2005, p. 44) summarizes, “The major challenge comes from rejection of positivists’ assumptions, namely the rejection of a dualist, objectivist epistemology, and language as an accurate representation of objective reality (language as a mirror).” That is, interpretivists believe that subjects and objects are intimately bound together, that reality is socially constructed, and thus that the meaning of language is also socially constructed (Sandberg 2005). The closest one can get to “objectivity” is consensual subjectivity. That is, if enough people think that 0.05 is the objective cutoff for significance tests, then it is considered objective—even if that objectivity is socially constructed. Hence, applications of criteria such as reliability, validity, and replicability—as used by positivist researchers—are problematic. Replicability, or “obtaining the same findings

and arriving at the same conclusions across...studies” (Pratt et al. 2024, p. 465), does not conform to a worldview where everything is dynamic and in flux. Instead, one would expect findings to *not* replicate—although researchers would endeavor to figure out why. Indeed, even Lincoln & Guba (1985) ultimately came to question whether their naturalistic criteria were interpretivist enough—that is, whether they overly reflected positivist assumptions (Welch & Piekkari 2017). The movement to articulate nonpositivist quality criteria in qualitative research may be viewed as addressing three fundamental challenges. Although the challenges are interrelated, each has been met in distinct ways.

Differences in Interpretivist Perspectives

The term “interpretivist” is broad and captures a range of beliefs. Amis & Silk (2008) capture some of these differences by distinguishing among “foundationalist,” “quasi-foundationalist,” and “nonfoundationalist” research orientations. Foundationalist refers to researchers who align with positivism. The other two orientations are both interpretivist but differ in the following ways:

Quasi-foundationalist researchers offer a departure from a foundationalist search for an objective reality by instead advocating for a subtle or nonnaive neorealism that searches for an approximation of reality.... Such work places an emphasis on the generation of generic theory that is empirically grounded and scientifically credible and produces findings that can be generalized to other contexts.... *Nonfoundationalists* contend that there can be no theory-free knowledge and thus relativism is inevitable.... [N]onfoundationalists propose that there is no possibility of uncovering neutral social facts; rather they hold that all knowledge is value-laden. (Amis & Silk 2008, p. 457)

Central to quasi-foundationalist approaches is the rigor of one’s methods (Amis & Silk 2008): A researcher’s own biases can be minimized by engaging in the right research practices. I have discussed the rise of templates when discussing new developments in how qualitative researchers conduct research, but their emergence also speaks to the issue of quality. The assumption underlying their use is that standardized approaches are associated with higher-quality research (Gioia et al. 2013). This puts quality as a function of how one designs and implements a study and how one analyzes one’s data. From a nonfoundationalist standpoint, however, quality is less a function of *how* one does one’s research (i.e., methodological rigor) than *why* one does so. Thus, nonfoundationalists highlight the importance of researchers’ intent or moral purpose (e.g., to emancipate workers) of the research (Amis & Silk 2008, Leitch et al. 2010). Good research is done for the right (moral) reasons.

Interpretivists also vary on other key assumptions. For some, such as Gioia and colleagues (2013), informants are knowledgeable, and thus one can readily build on their insights to build theory. Others, however, question this assumption, believing that the researcher may need to uncover truths not fully known by the researched or not fully shared (Mees-Buss et al. 2022). Thus, what informants say should not be taken at face value. Moreover, some believe that researchers are able to be conscious of and ultimately overcome their own biases, while others cast this assumption in doubt, especially as one moves toward a nonfoundationalist stance (Amis & Silk 2008).

Given the differences among interpretivist researchers, delineating common quality criteria is neither likely nor desirable. Consequently, those who embrace different “flavors” of interpretivist research have contributed to qualitative methods by crafting quality criteria that fit their ontological and epistemological approaches. Some of these approaches are illustrated in **Table 3**. As noted, criteria from the Gioia Method are quasi-foundationalist. Leitch and colleagues’ (2010) notion of ethical validation, however, follows more closely to a nonfoundationalist stance.

Table 3 Evolution in how we assess qualitative research

Assessment	Defining questions/definitions	Source
Convincing	<i>Authenticity</i>: That the author was “there” in the field and was genuine to the experience (i.e., did not do violence to experience) <i>Plausibility</i>: Does the academic audience “buy” it in that it (a) makes sense and (b) makes a contribution? <i>Criticality</i>: Does it make you rethink your assumptions about the field or your own work?	Golden-Biddle & Locke 1993: “Appealing work: an investigation of how ethnographic texts convince”
Truth as intentional fulfillment	<i>Communicative validity</i>: Perceived fulfillment established by (a) a community of interpretation and dialogical conversation in data collection, (b) coherent interpretations, and (c) discussing findings with academic peers and practitioners <i>Pragmatic validity</i>: Viewing fulfillment in practice in the interview process (e.g., deliberately misunderstanding) or via observations/participant observation <i>Transgressive validity</i>: Showing the indeterminate nature of fulfillment through such techniques as looking for contradictions and ambiguity <i>Reliability</i>: Are the procedures for producing truth themselves trustworthy? Achieved by fostering one’s own “interpretive awareness”	Sandberg 2005, p. 59: “How do we justify knowledge produced within interpretive approaches?”
Validation	<i>Ethical validation</i>: Is one’s investigation useful to those studied? <i>Substantive validation</i>: Has the researcher taken efforts to reflect on their own biases throughout the research process (e.g., design, collection, analysis)? <i>Researcher quality</i>: Has the researcher made a “valid interpretation of their topic”? (See also minimizing “violence to experience”)	Leitch et al. 2010, p. 74: “The philosophy and practice of interpretive research in entrepreneurship: quality, validation, and trust”
Convincing	<i>Confident, clear, and candid rhetoric</i>: “Different narrative styles (from highly personalized to visual, to realist) that elegantly combine both journey and resulting theory. . .” (p. 33) <i>Solid and transparent methodological craftsmanship</i>: “Adhesion to canons (e.g., in the basic flow from introduction to problem statement, methods, data, discussion, and conclusion) on the one hand, and deviation from them on the other hand. . .” (p. 33) <i>Compelling, lively authenticity and energy</i>: “Energy in narrating the meanders of (particularized moments in) the everyday realities encountered in the field and conveying both the rich cognitive and emotional process of immersion and the synthetically substantiated theories—and elegantly oscillates between them” (p. 33) <i>Strong reflexivity</i>: “Reflexivity in terms of the writing as a cognitive process designed to reflect and relate to the readers’ worlds, yet asymmetrical enough to attract the audience’s full attention and scrutiny” (p. 33) <i>Touch of imagination, some brave abductive leaps</i>: “A trust in one’s mind, instincts, and intuition to trigger generative, insightful moments; the sagaciousness to understand and value such moments not merely as introspectively satisfactory, but as data in their own right, and, conjectured from them, novel sketches of seeing and organizing the world” (p. 33)	Jonsen et al. 2018: “Convincing qualitative research: What constitutes persuasive writing?”

(Continued)

Table 3 (Continued)

Assessment	Defining questions/definitions	Source
Rigor	<i>Logical consistency:</i> (a) Methodological coherence—consistency of ontological, empirical, and methodological assumptions with method and theoretical claims; and (b) logical coherence—“the extent to which there are explicit logical links provided in a manuscript that lead from data to theoretical presuppositions, to candidate theoretical frameworks, and to actual theoretical inferences” (p. 244) <i>Inference of the best explanation:</i> (a) Considering multiple explanations, (b) “contrastive reasoning” (p. 245), and (c) convergence of likeliest and loveliest explanations	Harley & Cornelissen 2022: “Rigor with or without templates? The pursuit of methodological rigor in qualitative research”
Interpretive rigor	<i>Data-interrogating heuristics:</i> “What is really going on here?” E.g., “data problematization, i.e., focusing on breakdowns and clues” and “skepticism towards data” (p. 421) <i>Theory-generating heuristics:</i> “What does this mean in theoretical terms?” E.g., “cycle of posing, verifying, rejecting thought trials, to produce plausible theories” and “skepticism towards theoretical interpretations” (p. 421) <i>Plausibility heuristics:</i> “How might I be wrong?” E.g., “theory interrogation: focusing on conflicting evidence” and “skepticism towards scientific credibility of theories” (p. 421)	Mees-Buss et al. 2022: “From templates to heuristics: how and why to move beyond the Gioia methodology”
Trustworthiness	<i>Competence:</i> Do researchers know what they are doing? (externally validated, such as citing appropriate sources) <i>Integrity:</i> Do the various methodological choices and moves “fit together”? (e.g., showing timeline for longitudinal research) <i>Benevolence:</i> Do the researchers show fidelity to their data? (e.g., not doing violence to experience; long time in field, using long quotes)	Pratt et al. 2022): “Moving beyond templates: a bricolage approach to conducting qualitative research”

Acknowledging Limitations to Objectivity but Not Succumbing to Relativism

A second challenge, which follows from the first, is nicely summarized by Sandberg (2005, p. 42) who notes, “even though objective knowledge may be untenable, most advocates of interpretive approaches want to reject going as far as taking a complete relativistic stance.” Put another way, the struggle for some interpretivist scholars is producing knowledge that not only provides deep, contextually rich insights into a particular group or context but also creates knowledge that is useful for understanding organizational issues beyond those represented in one’s particular studies. Thus, although recognizing that methods cannot be strong on generalizability and realism simultaneously (McGrath 1981, p. 184), they nonetheless believe that situational insights need not be purely idiosyncratic. Indeed, that is the premise behind naturalistic generalization: By deeply understanding one organization (or other context), one can gain insights into another (Pratt 2008, Stake 1995).

One response to this second challenge has been to seek out something akin to a middle-ground approach between strong objectivism and strong relativism, such as through quasi-foundationalist, naturalistic, or subtle realism approaches. The latter refers to “maintaining a view of language as both constructing new worlds and as referring to a reality outside of the text” (Seale 1999, p. 470). Sandberg (2005), for example, discusses an iterative approach to quality that is interpretivist but not relativistic; rather, it involves iterating among multiple conceptualizations of truth.

Some middle-ground approaches, however, can be problematic. For example, a particularly cogent critique of a naturalistic approach is provided by Mees-Buss et al. (2022). Using Van Maanen’s (1979) hermeneutic approach as a contrast with a naturalistic one, they argue how hermeneutics

provide a stronger response to three challenges inherent in interpretivist research: (a) “interpreting subjective field data,” (b) “confronting researcher subjectivity in the theorizing process,” and (c) “establishing plausibility of theoretical conclusions” (Mees-Buss et al. 2022, p. 417). For example, they view establishing a plausible conclusion as a function of “interpretive rigor” rather than “procedural rigor” (Mees-Buss et al. 2022, p. 417); that is, rigor is not about following a specific predetermined set of practices (i.e., templates) but about how the researcher works as a detective to iteratively and abductively test theoretical insights they view as provisional. They offer heuristics that facilitate interpretive rigor.

In a similar vein, Harley & Cornelissen (2022) view quality as emanating from a researcher’s reasoning, and they articulate different means through which such reasoning can be captured and expressed. For example, they argue for the importance of methodological coherence whereby there is an alignment between how one approaches one’s research and one’s ontological and epistemological approach. Although both Harley & Cornelissen (2022) and Mees-Buss and colleagues (2022) take an interpretivist approach, both believe that theoretical insights are possible and thus avoid strict relativism.

Communicating Quality

A third challenge is perhaps less philosophical and more pragmatic: Even if they do quality work, how does an interpretivist scholar communicate that to their audience? This concern is not divorced from the previous ones. Indeed, Harley & Cornelissen (2022, p. 247) note:

ultimately the rigor of a research project will be assessed based on written outputs in the form of articles and reports. . . . In this sense, the practice of writing and the writing and the rhetorical devices others use to persuade readers that their conclusions are justified (see Langley & Abdallah 2011; Locke & Golden-Biddle 1997) cannot be decoupled from considerations of rigor.

Some scholars approach this challenge by inducing quality criteria from existing research. Golden-Biddle & Locke (1993), for example, examined published ethnographies to explore how such texts convince their reviewers that they are of high quality. They suggest that criteria such as plausibility—that one’s findings both make sense and contribute to existing theory—are what make a study compelling, not one’s references to validity or reliability. A similar approach was taken later by Jonsen and colleagues (2018) who examined qualitative studies published in top management journals between 2009 and the middle of 2015. They also induced several criteria common to these articles (see **Table 3**). Their list touches upon some criteria noted by Golden-Biddle & Locke (1993), such as authenticity or showing that you were in the field, as well as highlighting the importance of rhetoric.

Pratt et al. (2022) similarly examine others’ published works, as well as their own, to explore how trustworthiness has been communicated. They organize various analytical moves under three characteristics of trustworthiness central to human interactions: competence, integrity, and benevolence. For example, they note the importance of benevolence or “maintaining fidelity to the data”: demonstrating that the authors have tried to portray the various voices of their informants and not squash them under their own theoretical assumptions (Pratt et al. 2022, p. 221). However, in their overall approach, which they refer to as methodological bricolage, trustworthiness ultimately requires using those analytic moves throughout the research process that best address one’s research questions. For example, process-related research questions may be supported by the analytical move of collecting longitudinal data. Moreover, they argue one should be mindful of one’s ontological and epistemological assumptions but not be unduly bound by them. One could, for example, adopt an analytic move from a method with a different ontological and epistemological perspective if one could justify its use. Thus, methodological bricolage is pragmatic in its approach.

In short, qualitative scholars have often approached the challenge of communicating quality inductively, looking at patterns across highly cited and influential qualitative studies to induce more general practices. In the process, they have articulated new ways of thinking about what makes high-quality qualitative research. Looking across approaches in **Table 3**, quality is viewed in two (nonexclusive) ways: (a) “doing things right” procedurally and (b) persuading the reader to see something (e.g., existing theory) in a new way.

Taking Stock of Assessing Quality

The past 45 years of qualitative research have led to considerable discussion and debate around articulating what makes for “good” qualitative research (Welch & Piekkari 2017). What binds these various projects together is a belief that positivist criteria cannot be simply and mindlessly transferred to qualitative research (Pratt et al. 2020). Despite sometimes large differences among interpretive approaches to quality, there are a few common themes that have emerged.

Perhaps most fundamental is the recognition that quality needs to be judged within the ontological and epistemological assumptions of one’s methods. As such, these assumptions need to be clear to the reader, and the criteria for quality need to be explained and justified within those assumptions. As noted, if a researcher adopts an analytical practice that does not align with their ontological and epistemological assumptions, they must justify their reason for doing so (Pratt et al. 2022). Relatedly, because research perspectives differ, even within interpretivism, it is incumbent upon the researcher to be as transparent as possible in delineating the choices they are making in their study, including their choice of context, sampling, data collection procedures, and their analytic moves (see Pratt 2008, Pratt et al. 2022). Interestingly, *ASQ* is now requesting such transparency in all their new qualitative submissions.

Another potential area of agreement is the importance of some type of triangulation; however, what triangulation means, how it is practiced, and even comfort with the term itself vary across different qualitative research perspectives. From a positivist—and even a naturalist—perspective, triangulation often involves data triangulation, whereby “trustworthiness” is bolstered when different data sources (e.g., interviews and observation) converge on a given finding. Other interpretivist perspectives view the use of multiple data sources as a means to reveal differences (not convergence)—namely, multiple perspectives on what is “true” (Seale 1999). That is, different sources of data are used to give voice, and possibly even explain, multiple or multi-vocal narratives within one’s study.

Finally, there are some basic principles of “good” interpretive qualitative papers. For example, picking up on the second use of triangulation, because interpretivists believe in a socially constructed world, multiple voices should be expressed in one’s studies. That is, researchers should avoid the temptation to write their findings such that one—often the most powerful—entity (e.g., coalition, group, individual) is the only voice that is heard. Moreover, because inductive (and abductive) qualitative research is meant to understand the worldview of one’s informants, one should attempt to “minimize violence to experience” (Pratt 2008, p. 499): to reflect one’s understanding of informants’ worldviews in scholarly writing to the best of one’s ability. This sentiment is related to calls for authenticity (Golden-Biddle & Locke 1997), researcher quality (Leitch et al. 2010), and benevolence (Pratt et al. 2022), and it underlies certain analytical moves, such as member checks (Locke & Velamuri 2009).

Because what you are writing is your understanding of your informants’ worldview, theorizing should also be provisional (Mees-Buss et al. 2022). This echoes Van Maanen’s (1979) concern about writing as a realist tale, where the writer is an omniscient authority. One needs to be reflexive and have the humility to know that one’s interpretation, though plausible, may not be the only or even

the best one. Moreover, such interpretations can change with time. The interpretivist belief in the provisional nature of “truth” echoes the positivist belief that all claims are falsifiable. However, for a positivist, this falsifiability is based on an objectivist belief that there is one true, discoverable reality.

REFLECTIONS ON WHAT IS AHEAD

New developments in qualitative research have been characterized by movement and ongoing tensions. Movement toward making implicit knowledge more explicit and movements toward standardization have been met with greater pushes for craftsmanship and creativity. Movement away from using only positivist criteria for judging the quality of qualitative research has been met with several challenges, such as how to acknowledge the socially constructed nature of reality without falling into extreme relativism. Such tensions are dynamic, interrelated, and not likely to be completely resolvable. Grappling with them drives methodological advancements. Beyond these ongoing tensions, however, there are new challenges and opportunities ahead that will inspire the next phases of methodological evolution.

Global Proliferation of Qualitative Research

Qualitative scholars conduct their research across the globe. However, our top management and psychology journals continue to publish in English. Although problematic for organizational scholarship generally (Tietze & Dick 2013), this has special significance for qualitative research, as it causes—at minimum—a “double translation” problem, which increases the potential for violence to experience. Coding and analysis of data always involve one type of translation: moving from informants’ insights/wisdom to theory (Pratt 2023). Each qualitative method has its own means of making that translation possible, but there is always slippage. Translating from one language to another also causes slippage in meaning, even if one uses practices such as back translation where an interview is transcribed in its native language, translated into another language (e.g., English), and translated back to the original language and compared with the original transcript (Chidlow et al. 2014). For example, there are words that simply do not have meaningful English translations (Outila et al. 2019). Thus, informants’-worldview-translation-to-theory slippage is compounded by language-translation slippage. Barros & Alcadipani (2023) describe a similar double translation problem, noting challenges in both language translation and changes in writing styles. Writing styles of English-language journals may differ from the writing styles of one’s native-language journals. This hinders written expression of the lived experience of one’s informants, a central element of qualitative research.

Digging deeper, even more challenges become apparent. For example, the double translation problem only covers representation of knowledge by the researcher. There are also issues when non-English-speaking researchers face English-speaking evaluators (e.g., reviewers), as evaluators’ misunderstandings create higher hurdles for publication (cf. Tietze & Dick 2013). Yet more problems occur when the theories one draws upon to facilitate understanding are themselves translations. Issues of language and translation are interwoven with issues of culture and power, which raises even more challenges.

Since most of the world does not speak or read English, we need to pay more attention to language-related issues moving forward. Unfortunately, as Chidlow and colleagues (2014, p. 571) note, even in international business, qualitative researchers “largely do not account for their translation decisions in their reporting.” There are some exceptions, such as those advocating for a more contextual approach to translation (see Chidlow et al. 2014, Outila et al. 2019, Xian 2008), but such approaches need broader dissemination and discussion. There are no easy

answers—especially because having a common language facilitates knowledge sharing (Tietze & Dick 2013). However, raising the issue is a first step. Moreover, eliminating the practice of viewing research outside of North America as a “limitation” and having more international scholars as editors and reviewers are certainly movements in the right direction—and ones that are happening, albeit slowly.

Challenges to Positivist Social Science

Qualitative methods have become more legitimate in the past 45 years, and part of that journey has been educating quantitative researchers about qualitative methods and how to assess them. Recent events, however, have the potential to stall or reverse this progress. Specifically, social science has been roiled by scandals involving a “replication crisis” stemming the falsification of data, p-hacking, and p-harking. Moreover, journals are incorporating open science procedures to help resolve the replication crisis and to combat unethical research practices more generally.

Qualitative researchers, especially interpretivists, may wonder why such events matter for them. Yet, the reverberation from these events can have a tremendous impact for all qualitative researchers, especially those publishing in top-tier journals. There may be pressures for qualitative researchers to adopt practices employed by quantitative methodologists, such as preregistering one’s study and sharing data—practices that are either impossible, untenable, or at times unethical in qualitative research (see Pratt et al. 2020). Thus, if adopting open science is viewed as the gold standard, and these practices are untenable for much qualitative research,⁵ then there is a danger of viewing qualitative methods as substandard or less legitimate.

The reverberations from the challenges to positivist science pose additional questions and challenges to the qualitative research community. For example, are there procedures that can be put into place to minimize faulty research, or worse, researcher fraudulence? The former issue is often tackled via proper socialization, or in the review process with trained editors and reviewers, and is facilitated by the author’s transparency regarding the decisions made during the various phases of the research process (see **Figure 1**). Moreover, this topic has been extensively addressed in discussions of how to assess the quality of qualitative research (see the section titled *Advancements in Assessing Quality*). The latter issue, researcher fraudulence, has received less attention.

There could be at least two ways that researchers could practice deception. First, researchers could take data out of context for the purpose of imposing their own worldview onto the data, rather than doing justice to the voices of their informants. To illustrate, an author could use snippets of quotes to support a claim that is not justified by their broader corpus of data. For data such as interview data, such deception can be minimized if authors use more complete quotes rather than short snippets. Such a practice, however, would involve longer quotations and thus require more journal space than a traditional quantitative article, possibly entailing policy changes at some journals. Second, researchers could fabricate data.⁶ Data fabrication raises the question: When might it occur? I think it would most likely be done to support a construct where

⁵ Some qualitative research, such as research that utilizes publicly accessible data, could adopt the practice of sharing one’s data. If, however, one is bound by an informed consent document that promises both anonymity and confidentiality, some data—such as interview data—cannot be shared in this manner.

⁶ As personal aside, I have found questions about “making up data” in qualitative research to be surprising. In my experience, informants say much more interesting things than I could ever think up. Moreover, since I do not have a hypothesis to support, I have never felt pressure to make my data say anything in particular. Rather, my challenge has been delving into completely new literatures based on where the data take me. That said, I am not naïve enough to think that such cheating cannot happen in qualitative research.

one's data are weak. This could follow from trying to impose one's own worldview onto one's study, or in response to reviewers' pressure for more data on ill-supported constructs. Proper education of qualitative researchers and evaluators (e.g., questioning constructs versus simply demanding more data) is critical to avoid this. However, before offering specific recommendations, it would be helpful to better understand the prevalence and nature of this potential problem.

Another set of questions involve the appropriateness of something like open science practices for qualitative research, and if deemed appropriate, what they might look like. Any such attempt to craft such practices should involve input from qualitative researchers from different traditions, including those with different ontological and epistemological assumptions. Otherwise, it would be easy to fall into the same trap discussed earlier about applying positivist criteria for quality mindlessly onto qualitative research. Moreover, if such practices were considered, a further challenge would be to create fair assessment systems for our journals that avoid rigid "separate but equal" standards for qualitative and quantitative research. Since qualitative research remains in the minority of organizational research conducted, the temptation to judge one set of standards—and research that utilizes it—as inferior would be high.

In short, challenges to positivist science have the potential to undermine the legitimacy of all research. Thus, qualitative researchers need to consider how to respond. Questions involving the capacity to produce fake data, and possibly to detect it, also relate to the next trend that will shape the development of qualitative research: the emergence of AI.

Emergence of Artificial Intelligence

As we look forward to the future, the role of technology in qualitative methods is also likely to become a central issue, especially as AI continues to develop. Since scholars are just beginning to tackle AI's potential methodological implications, I offer some questions to ponder.

AI could influence the entire research process. Will scholars use AI to review the literature and come up with research topics or questions? Will researchers codesign their projects with AI, including sampling decisions? If we use AI to transcribe our interviews, do we know where that information goes, especially if the software uses inputted data to influence AI machine learning? Could AI undermine confidentiality? How might AI influence the coding and analysis of data? Can AI "make sense" of the data for someone? How might this work, and what assumptions should be in place when making these decisions? For example, would a researcher view an interview text at face value and use AI to look for obvious patterns? Who might program AI to do this, and/or who might serve as experts in advising AI programming? Alternatively, if you believe that informants lie or do not know themselves enough to provide "truthful" answers, can a researcher use AI to ferret out inconsistencies, ambiguities, and "what isn't being talked about"? How might AI affect the standardization-creativity tension? And as noted above, how might AI be used to fabricate data or possibly detect such fabrication?

In higher education, we are already grappling with students using AI in their writing. What role, if any, should AI play in how one writes one's text? Few may object to its checking grammar, but what about crafting whole arguments: AI as coauthor? Qualitative scholars are—individually and collectively—currently pondering these issues. How we answer could have significant implications on our craft and how it continues to evolve.

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